

1625–1790

MASQUERADE

Since medieval times dressing up had been popular all over Europe. In the Middle Ages masked mummers (travelling actors) performed in village pageants and travelled from house to house in Carnival season, which lasted from Christmas until Lent. During Carnival, the Catholic Church allowed merry-making and open-air festivities, so bands of masked revellers regularly paraded through the streets. During the Renaissance people performed set scenes in elaborate processional pageants. By the 18th century Carnival was celebrated all over Italy, with Venice leading the fashion for lively masquerades (masked balls and entertainments), held at night and lit with flickering candles and torches. This trend soon became popular in France and England too, possibly because shadows and masks encourage relaxed behaviour. The term “masquerade” specifically described dressing as particular characters, but these extravagant events led to the more general practice of displaying wealth and social position by wearing “fancy dress” – formal clothes with small elements of masquerade added.

Domino In Venice a masquerade cloak was known as a *domino*, and this garment came to typify a masked character with an air of intrigue and adventure. During the 18th century these figures (who could be male or female) were particularly popular in London.

1750s

Costume cloaks were always hooded, black, and voluminous



Gown and hooped petticoat fit underneath cloak

1789

Fashionable gown of the period



Costumes from Middle Ages popular for masquerades

Cloaked characters often wore a white mask, here perched on the typical tricorne (three-cornered) hat

Pointed hat with a veil

Mask for fancy-dress ball

Full naval-commander costume

Turban headdress

Shalvar (baggy trousers) for Turkish costume

Hooked nose identifies Pulcinella

Many women, not just nuns, wore wimples in the Middle Ages

Dressed as a monk

Female players, rare in *commedia dell'arte*, usually dressed as figures from the past

1650

Long, medieval-style skirt had to be held up for walking

Commedia dell'arte This comic open-air entertainment, first seen in Venice, may have been connected to Carnival. The travelling players, dressed as stock characters such as Harlequin and Pulcinella, probably performed at early masquerades, providing costume inspiration.

Sources of inspiration Masqueraders took their costume ideas from varied sources – the exotic cultures of Africa and the Orient, the past, political and social scandals, fairy tales, and extreme fashions. For late-1700s fancy-dress balls, guests accessorized their best contemporary clothes and wore a mask.